

1545 ▶ 1570

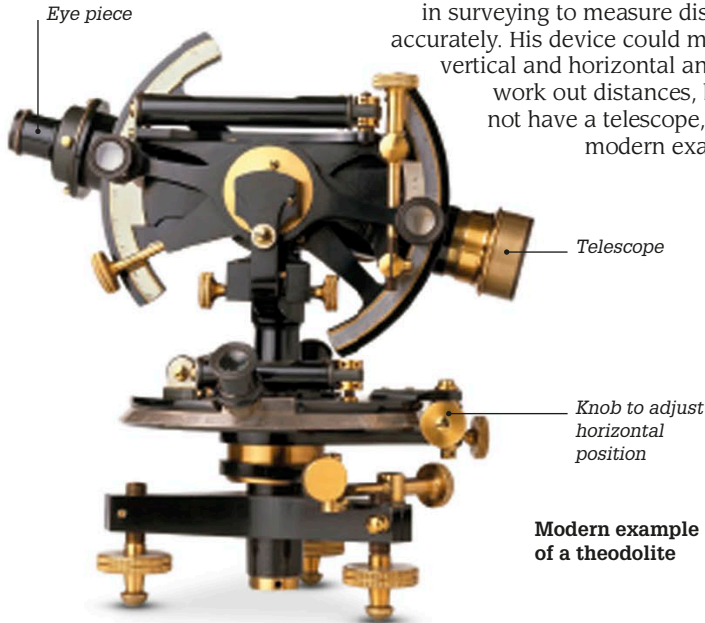


All the platinum ever mined would fit in an average-sized living room.

1551

Measuring distances

English surveyor Leonard Digges invented an early theodolite, an instrument used in surveying to measure distances accurately. His device could measure vertical and horizontal angles to work out distances, but did not have a telescope, unlike modern examples.



Platinum nugget



1551

Prolific inventor

Islamic scientist Taqi al-Din wrote a book describing how a steam turbine worked. He also invented the first weight-driven astronomical clock, clocks that measured minutes and seconds, and an early telescope.

1557

Rare metal

Italian scholar Julius Caesar Scaliger wrote that Spanish explorers in Mexico had found a substance that did not melt at high temperatures and did not rust. It is the first known reference in European writings to platinum, one of Earth's rarest metals.



1545

1550

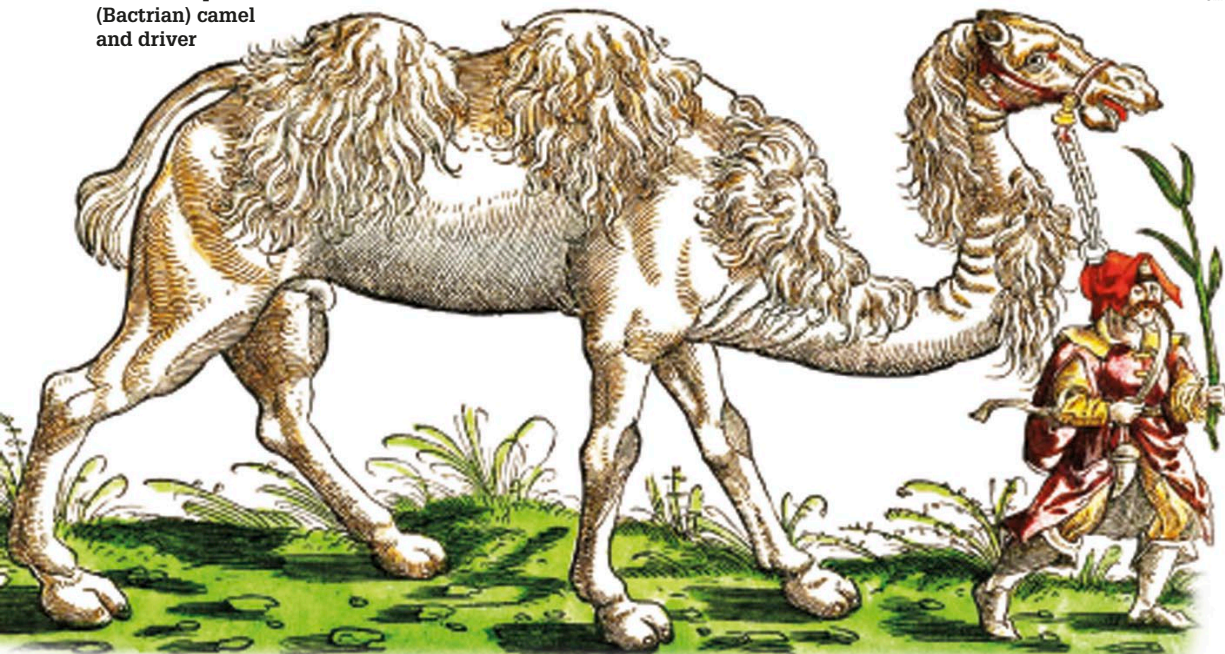
1555

1551

Animal magic

Swiss naturalist Konrad von Gesner set out to catalog all the world's animals in his five-volume *Historiae Animalium* (History of Animals), one of the first works of zoology. Although his colorful drawings are noted for their accuracy, he included some fictional beasts such as unicorns.

Gesner's illustration of a two-humped (Bactrian) camel and driver



1557

Math symbols

Welsh mathematician Robert Recorde wrote *The Whetstone of Witte*, the first book on algebra in English. He popularized the use of + (plus) and - (minus) signs, and is credited with inventing the = (equals) sign.

Traveling the world
See pages 92-93